QUARTERLY INDEX

Capacity is not the whole story.

ALDER +3.8%	BRACKEN +4.2%	CEDAR +3.7%	DOVETAIL +2.7%
ELM +4%	FALLOW +4.9%	GROVE +1.9%	HARROW +3.5%
ILEX +4.2%	JUNIPER +2.9%	KESTREL +4%	LARCH +3.8%

TWELVE OPERATORS / ONE SYNTHETIC MODEL
Volume, service and the cost of getting busier.

Read the system.

One theme, from the operating floor to the comparison table.

4	Cover story / capacity with room to move
8	Data / where the work goes
10	Profile / the dispatch coordinator
12	Analysis / growth and service
16	Briefing / questions for a capacity review
18	Opinion / count what the target hides
20	Case study / Cedar at a steadier pace
24	Market table / twelve model operators
26	Agenda / an internal review calendar
27	Reader page / sources and next issue

All operator names and quantitative examples are invented. The ranking is an editorial model, not market research.

A number needs a second question.

What changed, and what did it cost to change it?

A capacity target can be easy to print and difficult to interpret. More orders through the same building sounds like progress. Yet a single total does not tell us whether dispatches were late, work had to be repeated or a busy week consumed the next week's margin.

This issue asks for a second question after every headline. When volume rises, what happened to service? When unit cost falls, what happened to the total bill? When a ranking changes, which measure carried the most weight?

We have built a small synthetic operating world so those questions can be traced from page to page. Twelve invented operators supply the comparison table. Cedar supplies a separate weekly before-and-after example. Neither is a survey or a client result.

The purpose is editorial clarity: every chart has a denominator, every rank has a formula, and every case result has a limitation.

EDITORIAL, DESIGN & NATIVE PRODUCTION

Ayobami

Original native diagrams and model data. Formulas and provenance records are packaged under CONTENT.

Capacity with room to move.

A reserve is a decision.
Give it a job before you give it a size.

PLAN A / EVERY SLOT COMMITTED



An exception must displace planned work.

PLAN B / A NAMED RESERVE



Conceptual slots only. No universal buffer percentage or measured queue effect is proposed.

The unused hour is not always waste.

A plan can be efficient on paper and fragile in practice.

Imagine two dispatch plans. The first fills every available hour with expected work. The second leaves a small part of the day unassigned. If demand arrives exactly as forecast, the first plan appears to win: less spare time, the same output. But the comparison changes when an order needs checking or a delivery arrives late.

The spare hour then has a job. It allows the team to respond without immediately displacing the next task. That does not make every empty hour valuable. A buffer needs a purpose, a size and a review date. Otherwise it becomes a convenient name for poor scheduling.

The distinction is between capacity held for a defined uncertainty and capacity left idle without an explanation. A useful review asks what the reserve protected and whether the same work could have been handled another way.

This issue treats the reserve as a design decision, not a universal percentage. The synthetic Cedar example changes three elements together: planned base operations, rework and overtime. Its results demonstrate the accounting questions a reader should ask, rather than prove a rule for every warehouse.

Start with the work mix on page 8. Receiving, put-away, picking, packing and dispatch share the same working day, but not the same constraints. A busy picking area can coexist with a quiet loading area. A whole-building utilisation figure can conceal that difference.

Then compare the service measures on pages 14 and 15. Volume is one dimension. Timeliness and accuracy describe different parts of the promise to the customer. A change that improves one while damaging another needs an explanation before it becomes a success story.

Editorial argument illustrated by synthetic data. No measured relationship between utilisation and queues is claimed.

Follow the hand-off.

The next stage is part of the current stage's capacity.

A local target encourages a local answer. Receiving wants the dock cleared. Picking wants the wave complete. Packing wants a clean queue. Each can look successful while work accumulates between them.

The hand-off is therefore a useful unit of attention. What moves forward? Who accepts it? Which information travels with it? What happens when the receiving stage has more work than the next stage can use? These questions describe a proposed review, not an observed failure at a named company.

In the model, forty per cent of working time is assigned to picking. That large share does not automatically make picking the bottleneck. A smaller stage may still govern the completion of an order. The chart shows allocation; it does not measure constraint.

Avoid asking one diagram to establish two different facts. The work-mix bar tells us how the synthetic day is divided. The dispatch measure tells us the share completed on time. Neither proves the cause of the other.

The native process diagram on page 9 keeps the stages visible without implying a measured cycle time. It gives the reader a language for the analysis: input, hand-off, decision, output and exception.

A review should preserve those distinctions. If a team changes the release rhythm and the staffing plan at the same time, a later improvement cannot be attributed to only one change. Record the bundle, show the result and identify the uncertainty. That is a stronger editorial account than a clean but unsupported causal story.

The diagram is an original process model. Stage shares are synthetic allocations, not an industry average.

Keep three measures in the conversation.

Volume, service and cost reveal different trade-offs.

01 / VOLUME

+3.5%

Quarter orders rise from 1.466m to 1.518m. Aggregate growth uses the Q1 total as its base; it is not the mean of twelve growth rates.

02 / SERVICE

60 / 40

The rank weights on-time dispatch at 60% and accuracy at 40%. Keep both component measures visible beside the score.

03 / COST

-5.3%

Cedar's weekly unit cost falls from GBP 3.80 to 3.60, but its weekly bill rises from GBP 15,200 to 15,840 as order volume grows.

Quarter: pp. 12-15, 24-25 / Separate weekly Cedar model: pp. 20-23

Where the day goes.

Synthetic working-time allocation / total 100%

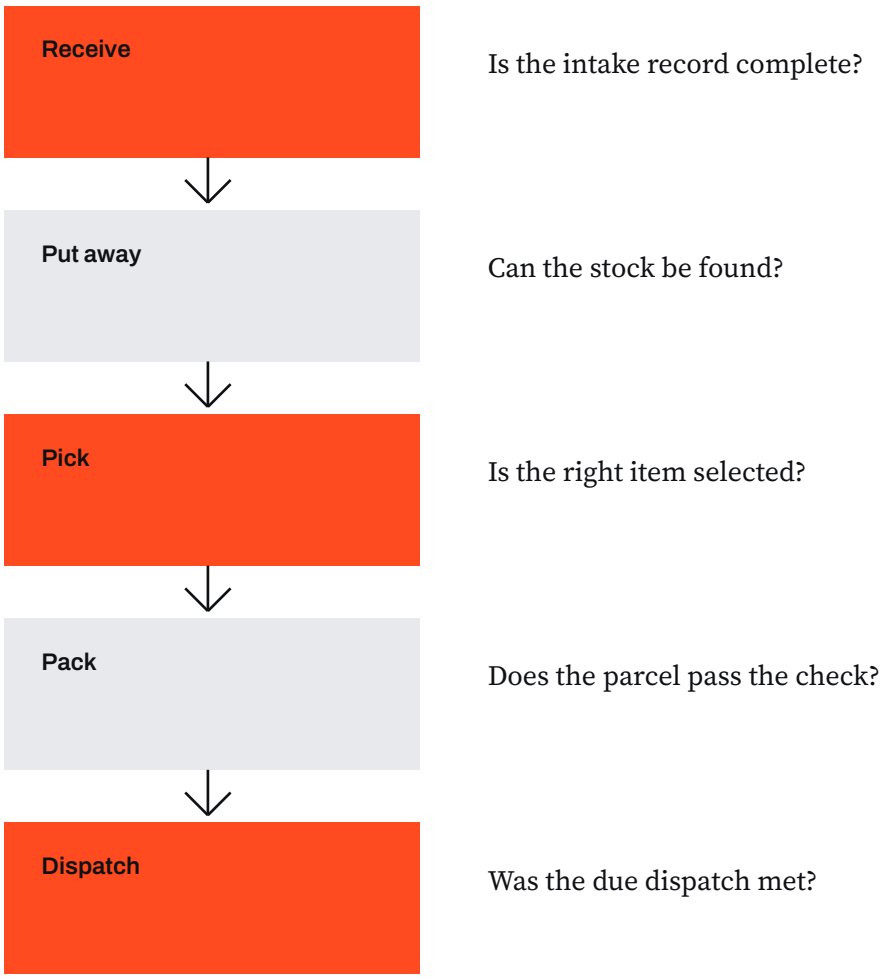


Receive	**12%**
Put away	**18%**
Pick	**40%**
Pack	**20%**
Dispatch	**10%**

12 + 18 + 40 + 20 + 10 = 100. Allocation describes the model day; it does not identify a bottleneck.

Five stages.
One order promise.

A native process model, with explicit hand-off questions.



Original schematic. No measured time, staffing ratio or automation performance is inferred from the diagram.

The dispatch coordinator.

A proposed role, made visible through the state of the work.

READY

Release

Check the release conditions.
Choose the next wave.
Record the acceptance.

HELD

Resolve

Name the missing condition.
Assign a decision owner.
Set the next review time.

COMPLETE

Hand over

Confirm the dispatch.
Record the hand-off.
Carry open decisions forward.

Original state-and-decision schematic. No employee interview, live queue or measured system is depicted.

Make the exception visible early.

A working brief for the coordinator in our editorial model.

The coordinator's proposed task is to keep the status of work legible. Ready, held and complete are different states. A held order needs a reason and an owner; a ready order needs a route into the next release; a completed order needs a recorded hand-off.

The role should not become a substitute for every other decision. If inventory data is wrong, the issue belongs to the system that creates and maintains it. If a service promise exceeds capacity, the coordinator cannot solve that mismatch by rearranging the queue indefinitely.

A useful shift note can be short: what is waiting, why it is waiting, who can release it and when it must be reviewed. The form matters less than whether the next person can act without recreating the investigation.

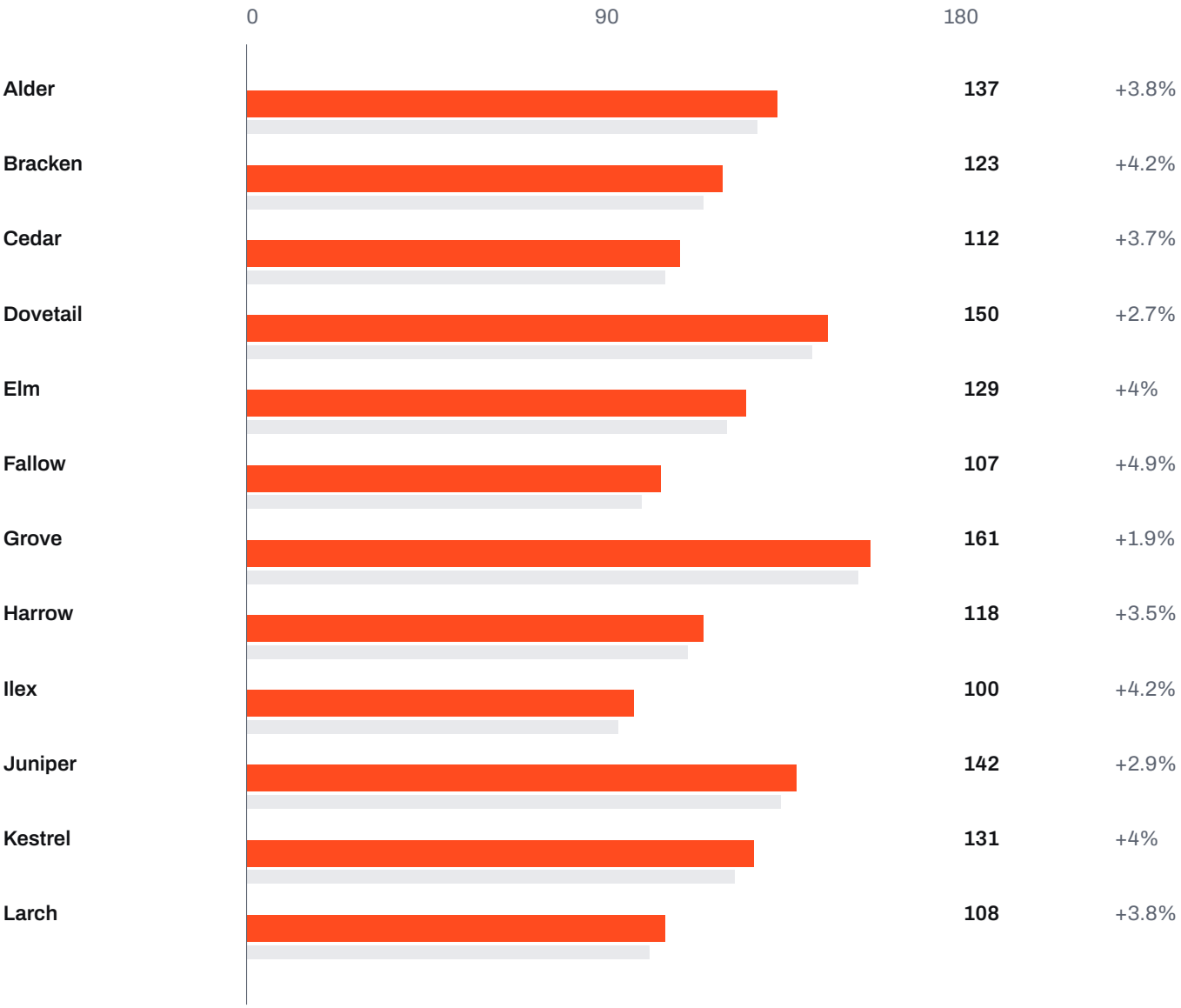
In the Cedar case, the role blueprint accompanies a changed release plan. The example does not isolate the role's contribution. It describes a bundle of proposed changes and the synthetic results assigned to that bundle.

The profile therefore carries no invented biography, quotation, qualification or employment claim.

Role blueprint / original editorial writing / no employee testimonial or observed performance claim.

Who drove the growth?

Q1 to Q2 / thousand orders / shared scale



Q2: orange / Q1: grey. All bars start at zero.
Grove leads volume; Fallow leads percentage growth.

Synthetic operators and periods. Comparison uses the source model, not a real-world market survey.

Growth has a denominator.

+3.5%

52,000 more orders.
Not twelve identical stories.

The model rises from 1,466,000 to 1,518,000 orders. Dividing the 52,000 increase by the Q1 total gives 3.5% after rounding. This is aggregate growth, not an average of the twelve percentages.

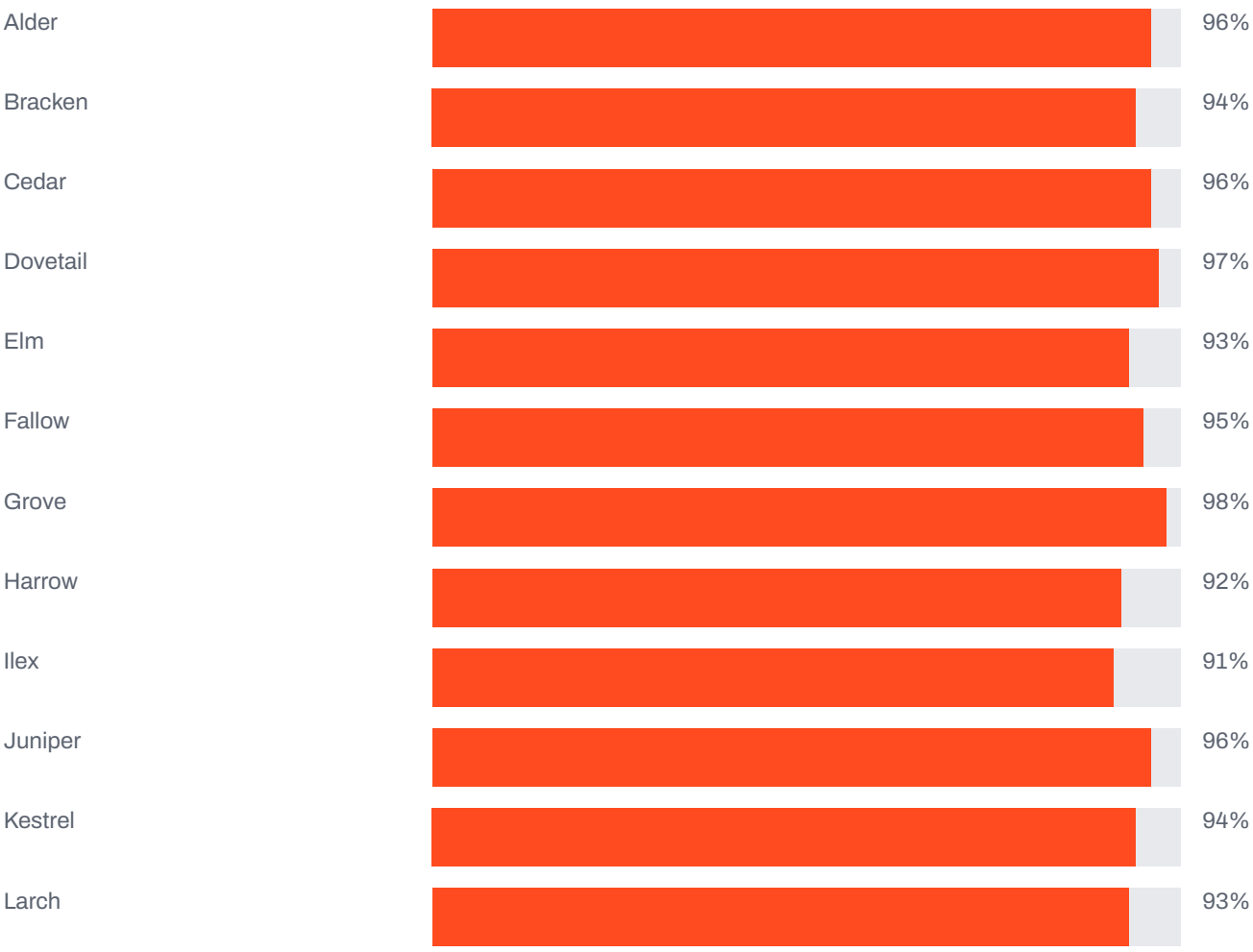
Fallow rises from 102,000 to 107,000: 4.9%. Grove rises from 158,000 to 161,000: 1.9%. A smaller percentage can accompany a larger operation. Keep volume and rate together.

READ THE PERIOD AS WELL AS THE NUMBER

This quarter model is separate from Cedar's weekly before-and-after case. Combining their totals would create a false comparison.

Service remains a separate question.

Q2 on-time dispatch / percent / twelve model operators



Shared zero baseline / maximum 100%

Zero baseline, 0–100%. Direct labels preserve small differences. Synthetic dispatches due in Q2 are the denominator.

A score is a choice about emphasis.

60% on-time dispatch + 40% checked-order accuracy

The ranking combines two percentages with weights that sum to one. On-time dispatch receives sixty per cent of the emphasis; accuracy receives forty per cent. Grove scores 98.64: 0.60 multiplied by 98, plus 0.40 multiplied by 99.6.

The formula does not transform the model into market evidence. It is a transparent editorial choice applied to twelve invented operators. A different weighting could change the order, especially among close scores.

Keep the component measures visible. Alder and Juniper both show 96% on-time dispatch, but their accuracy rates differ. That difference explains their score order without requiring the reader to reverse-engineer the formula.

Scores are displayed to two decimals so the calculation can be checked. That precision is computational, not statistical. No sample uncertainty or confidence interval is estimated because the dataset is authored rather than measured.

Ties are resolved by higher accuracy, then alphabetical operator name. The rule is fixed before the ranking is drawn. There is no hidden adjustment for revenue, size, margin, safety or customer satisfaction.

The table on page 25 is therefore a narrow service comparison inside an editorial model. It is not a company valuation, procurement recommendation or claim that a top-ranked operator is better in every respect.

Formula, tie-break and denominators are included in CONTENT/model.json. No real-company or investment claim.

The review agenda before the purchase.

Six questions for the next internal capacity discussion.

Demand	Which interval drives the plan: day, week or quarter?
Release rhythm	How much work enters each stage at once?
Inventory	What must be known before an order can be released?
Exceptions	Who owns a held order and its review time?
Handover	Which open decisions pass to the next shift?
Evidence	What would show that the change helped?

Proposed discussion prompts. No equipment supplier, certification or purchased system is recommended.

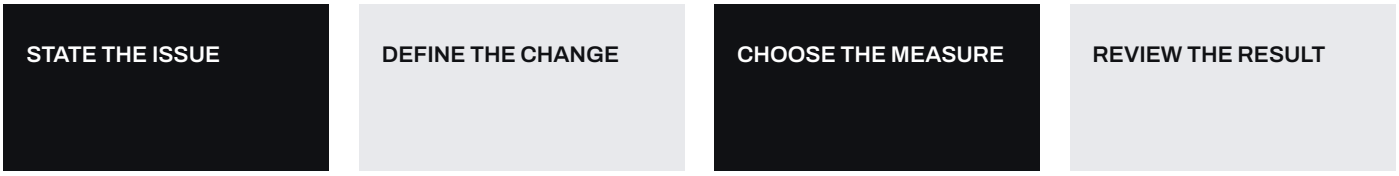
Do not buy an answer to an undefined question.

A decision brief should describe the work before the technology.

A proposal can be polished while its problem remains vague. More speed, better visibility and greater efficiency are ambitions, not a scoped operating requirement. A useful brief identifies the work that is delayed, repeated or difficult to hand over.

Then describe the boundary. Which orders, shifts and stages are included? What information is available? Who will maintain it? What happens when the new process is unavailable? Those questions make a comparison possible without assuming that a larger system is the right response.

In this editorial model, a release plan and an exception owner are changes a team could define before selecting any product. That does not prove they are sufficient. It demonstrates a sequence: state the issue, describe the proposed change, define the measure and review the result.



Original decision brief. This sequence is a proposed review, not a procurement recommendation.

Count what the target leaves out.

Original editorial column / Ayobami

A target becomes dangerous when it is asked to stand for the whole system. Orders dispatched per hour may be useful. It does not tell us whether the right item was packed, whether a promise was met or whether another shift absorbed the unresolved work.

A second measure should not be chosen merely to make a dashboard look balanced. It should test the behaviour the first measure might encourage. If speed is rewarded, show rework. If unit cost is celebrated, show total cost and volume. If a service score is ranked, show its components.

The Cedar model demonstrates this discipline. Unit cost improves, but the weekly bill rises because volume rises too. Overtime hours fall, but the model also allocates a higher base-operations cost per order. The story is a trade-off, not a free gain.

An honest headline can still be strong. It simply names the boundary of the result. That boundary lets a reader decide whether the change matters for the question they are asking.

This column is original writing, not a quotation from an executive or an account of a client engagement.

If unit cost is celebrated, show total cost and volume.

Opinion grounded in the authored model, not an empirical industry study.

The meeting needs a stopping rule.

A review is useful when it can change the next decision.

A review without a decision can become a ceremony. The team gathers the numbers, explains the exceptions and leaves with the same plan. Before the meeting, identify what would justify continuing, changing or stopping the trial.

For the synthetic Cedar example, a useful decision note would put service, rework, overtime and cost on the same page. It would also show what changed in the operating plan, so the result is not detached from its inputs.

Do not write a stopping rule after seeing the result and present it as if it were fixed beforehand. Preserve the initial question and record revisions. A clear note should distinguish an agreed decision from an unresolved question.

The review calendar on page 26 gives an internal example. It is a sequence of checkpoints, not an advertised conference programme or an invitation to a functioning event.

CONTINUE	REVISE	STOP
The agreed rule is met.	The question still matters; the plan needs to change.	The agreed limit is reached.

Define the rule before the trial. These are decision categories, not prescribed numeric thresholds.

Less per order. More in total.

A steadier pace does not mean a smaller bill.

ORDERS / WEEK		
4,000	4,400	+10.0%
UNIT COST / GBP		
3.80	3.60	-5.3%
TOTAL COST / GBP		
15,200	15,840	+4.2%

Values read BEFORE to AFTER. Scenario comparison; multiple inputs change together.

Change the bundle. Record the boundary.

Cedar is invented. Its before-and-after results are authored.

The Cedar case starts with a four-thousand-order week and ends with a four-thousand-four-hundred-order week. The operating plan changes as a bundle: a steadier release rhythm, an explicit exception owner and a larger base-operations allowance.

The model assigns lower rework and overtime to the after state. These are not observed effects. They are scenario values chosen to demonstrate how a case study can expose both an improved unit cost and a higher total bill.

Do not infer that release planning alone produced the result. The design changes several inputs together and contains no control group. It is an accounting and editorial example.

The before state dispatches 91% on time; the after state dispatches 96% on time. Rework falls from 3% to 2% of weekly orders. Because the denominator grows, that becomes 120 orders requiring rework before and 88 after.

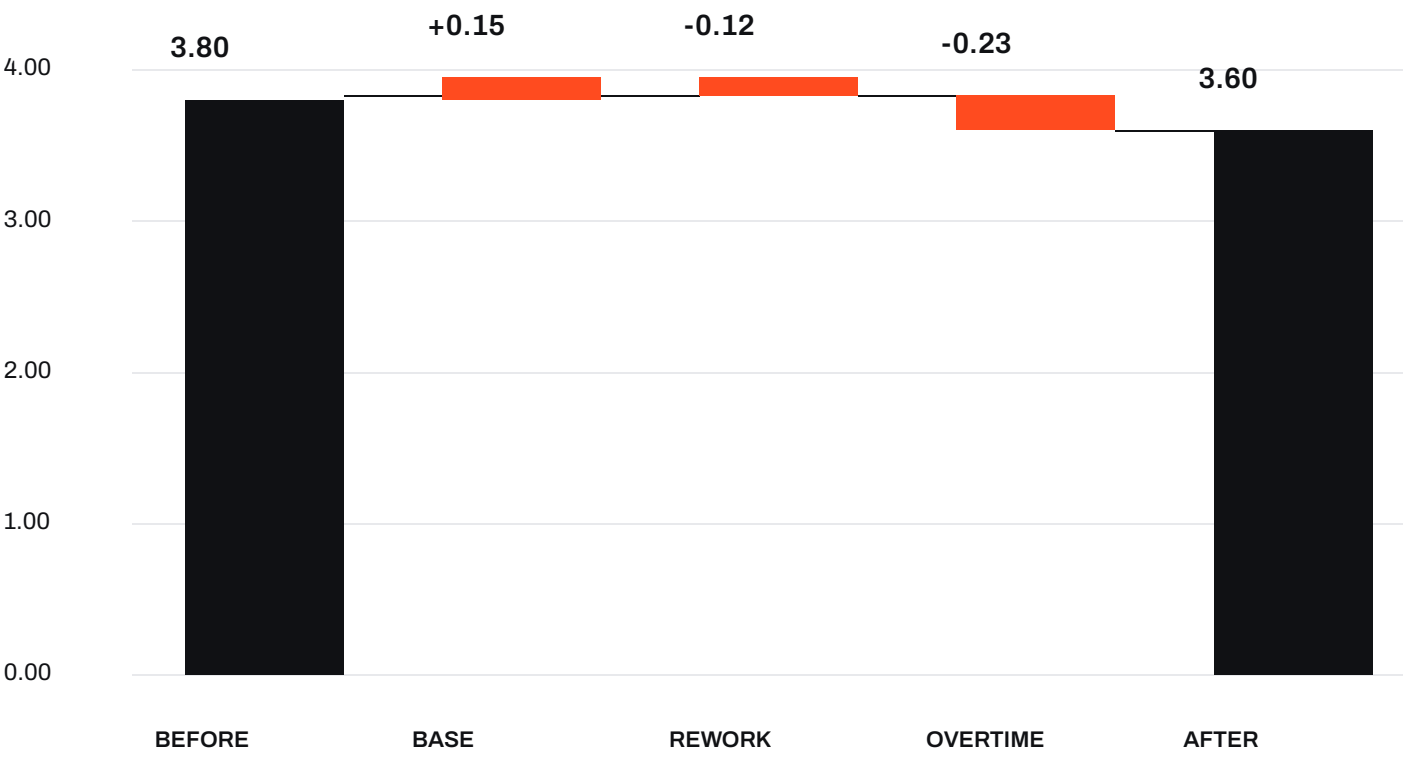
Overtime falls from 180 to 120 hours per week. The base-operations cost per order rises from GBP 3.00 to GBP 3.15. The cost bridge on the next page shows how that increase is offset by smaller rework and overtime allowances.

The quarter table describes a separate aggregation of Cedar's model activity. It should not be used to claim that this weekly scenario was observed throughout a real quarter.

Model periods only. Several inputs change together; causal attribution and real savings claims are not supported.

Where the 20p went.

GBP per order / original synthetic weekly model



COMPONENT / GBP PER ORDER	BEFORE	AFTER
Base operations	3.00	3.15
Rework allowance	0.30	0.18
Overtime allowance	0.50	0.27

Before: 4,000 x GBP 3.80 = GBP 15,200/week
After: 4,400 x GBP 3.60 = GBP 15,840/week

Seven measures. One model week.

Before and after / synthetic weekly model

MEASURE / WEEKLY MODEL	BEFORE	AFTER
Orders / week	4,000	4,400
On-time dispatch	91%	96%
Rework / share	3%	2%
Rework / orders	120	88
Overtime / hours	180	120
Unit cost / GBP	3.80	3.60
Total cost / GBP	15,200	15,840

Column order: before / after.
Review limit: multiple inputs change together. No observed outcome, controlled trial or causal attribution is claimed.

Twelve operators.

Synthetic quarter data / orders in thousands

Operator	Q1 / k	Q2 / k	Growth	On time
Alder	132	137	3.8%	96%
Bracken	118	123	4.2%	94%
Cedar	108	112	3.7%	96%
Dovetail	146	150	2.7%	97%
Elm	124	129	4.0%	93%
Fallow	102	107	4.9%	95%
Grove	158	161	1.9%	98%
Harrow	114	118	3.5%	92%
Ilex	96	100	4.2%	91%
Juniper	138	142	2.9%	96%
Kestrel	126	131	4.0%	94%
Larch	104	108	3.8%	93%

Totals: Q1 1,466k / Q2 1,518k / +3.5%. Growth uses each Q1 base. On-time share uses model Q2 dispatches due.

Make the formula visible.

Score = 0.60 x on-time % + 0.40 x accuracy %

#	Operator	On time	Accuracy	Score
1	Grove	98%	99.6%	98.64
2	Dovetail	97%	99.5%	98.00
3	Juniper	96%	99.3%	97.32
4	Alder	96%	99.2%	97.28
5	Cedar	96%	99.0%	97.20
6	Fallow	95%	99.1%	96.64
7	Kestrel	94%	98.9%	95.96
8	Bracken	94%	98.8%	95.92
9	Elm	93%	98.7%	95.28
10	Larch	93%	98.6%	95.24
11	Harrow	92%	98.5%	94.60
12	Ilex	91%	98.4%	93.96

Descending score; ties: higher accuracy, then name. Computational precision, not statistical certainty. Twelve invented operators only.

A quarter worth reviewing.

Proposed checkpoints / no public events or booking links

Week 1 / Define

Fix the trial boundary, owner, denominator and decision rule. Preserve the initial question.

Week 4 / Check

Check that the measures can be reproduced. Record missing or inconsistent information before interpreting a trend.

Week 8 / Compare

Compare like periods and like orders. Show changed inputs alongside service, rework and cost.

Week 12 / Decide

Continue, revise or stop against the agreed rule. Record unresolved questions and the next review owner.

An illustrative internal calendar. No real venue, event organiser, admission price or registration service is represented.

Check the question behind the number.

Next issue: what happens after a return reaches the warehouse?

Reader prompt

Which measure in your own decision brief needs a clearer denominator? Write down the period, population and calculation before you compare the result.

DATA & EDITORIAL
Operational model and role framework. Supporting data and formulas accompany the publication.

GRAPHICS & PRODUCTION
Original capacity schematic, role-state board and Cedar weekly graphics: Ayobami. Charts and tables remain native and editable. CONTENT/model.json contains all source values and formulas.
No stock photograph is used in this revision. Earlier photographic references and attribution records are retained under CONTENT for provenance.

THE QUARTERLY INDEX

A clearer number. A better question.

ISSUE 01 / CAPACITY WITH ROOM TO MOVE
Original editorial and synthetic evidence.
Design and native production: Ayobami.